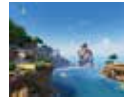




Nike Zoom Vaporfly 4%

Nike claims their new Zoom Vaporfly 4% running shoes will actually make professional athletes run faster. <http://digit.in/NikeVFLy>



Rime' is finally here

The adventure game 'Rime' that was first announced back in September 2013 is finally set to launch this May. <http://digit.in/RimeMay>

Feature



Do we really need scores of products in the same category?

product as the next big revolution in the fitness tracking market. What they bring out however, is a product with the exact same feature set and sometimes almost the same design as the rest, with the hopes that people will go after it based on brand value.

If there was innovation, at least in design, when it comes to fitness trackers, we would be looking at major brands diversifying their design from the standard bracelet type structure popularised by Fitbit to more diverse designs meant for different user groups. While all of us might be trying to do the same thing with fitness trackers, not all of us are the same to begin with. For instance, answer one question. If you think that this section was unwarranted - why isn't there a manual option to stop tracking on most fitness trackers when, say, you're on a vehicle?

Startups

Okay, before you start ranting about successful business models and all that, we DO know that the startup industry often works on taking an idea and bettering it. But more often than not, what actually happens is the taking of an idea and the slathering of more VC funds on it to attract more customers via offers.

Take a look at the food ordering segment in India - Foodpanda, TinyOwl, Zomato and Swiggy. While not all of them are failing, it is clear that Swiggy is leading the roost. The funding into

food startups had risen to a cool \$74 million in the first half of 2015 only to drop to a disappointing \$19 million in the second half. Offering discounts and cashbacks proved to be suicidal for most of the startups in this area, with TinyOwl shutting shop just last year. Among all of this, Swiggy has managed to raise another investment of \$5 million recently. Why? Because it became the differentiator.

Instead of focussing on cashbacks and discounts like every other food delivery startup, Swiggy's focus was on delivering within shorter times (Average delivery time on the app is 37 minutes) and to ensure traceability. This focus on service quality, instead of copying the discount business model is what made sure Swiggy survived the crunch. Similar stories are littered across the Indian startup scenario, where investors are backing out of companies that are losing money consistently due to too many discounts and too little customer loyalty once that's gone.

Internet of (another)things...

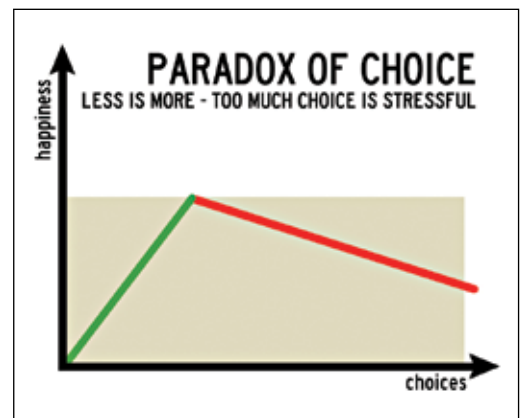
Or IoT as we have abbreviated it to - a buzzword that we have been hearing long enough to know that it's not a buzzword anymore. One of the primary areas where it is being used is home automation - there are market leaders like Amazon Alexa and now, Google Home which connect to numerous services and devices. One level below that lie the devices themselves. These are the gadgets and appliances that can replace your current 'unsmart' arsenal with capabilities like auto on-off, data insights, preset configurations and a lot more functionality. It's just that, they don't really do that.

Home automation companies, most of them to be fair, have been going after the standard hub-smart plug design in which all they offer is switch on-off capabilities from a smartphone. There's nothing wrong

with having basic features - but when almost an entire industry is doing the same thing, it's bound to kill innovation. Companies like Oakter, Inoho etc are busy building their own hubs and switchboards, which offer identical functionality with a few tweaks here and there. Cubical Labs with its Aura device, is the closest to becoming a differentiator. Home Brain is also offering complete solutions that seem more polished. But overall, there needs to be an urge towards innovation rather than replicating these models if we are to see something like Alexa or Google Home being built, sold, and used at all in India.

They're killing themselves?

Yes, they are. This trend of developing 'me too' products and features by tech companies and startups everywhere is a loss for the companies, as well as consumers in the long run. Companies end up offering customers products that were never really developed in the way that they promised in their marketing. Whilst in principle it is good having competition for the same product types from different



The paradox of choice is a recognised and proven phenomenon

companies, in practice, there is often not a big enough market to accommodate the same types of products with the same features and the same price points. It is perhaps one very good reason why following each other blindly is never going to be a particularly good idea.